CASE #07

Music and study: the evidence

WHAT THE RESEARCH FOUND

Researchers at Cardiff Metropolitan University (Perham & Currie, 2014) gave people a reading test while they listened to one of four things: **silence**, **music with no lyrics**, **songs with lyrics they liked**, or **songs with lyrics they disliked**.

Average reading scores

Why?

Words in a song compete with the words you're reading. Your brain has limited space to process language, so lyrics crowd out what you're trying to learn.

The surprise

It made no difference whether people liked the songs. Their favourite music still lowered their scores, even though it felt better.

So what should I do?

- New or tricky work: **silence** is best.
- If you need sound: music **without lyrics**, quietly.
- Save your favourite songs for breaks, or for easy jobs like tidying your notes.

Talk about it: why do so many people still study with their favourite songs on, if it doesn't help?

Source: Perham, N. & Currie, H. (2014). Applied Cognitive Psychology, 28(2), 279-284.